

GABRIEL POPA

Senior Software Engineer – Ruby on Rails • AWS

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ABOUT ME

Senior Software Engineer with 10+ years of experience building reliable web platforms, internal business systems, and customer-facing products with a strong specialization in **Ruby on Rails** application development, backend architecture, and full-stack delivery. Background spans **product engineering, business operations software, and data-driven web platforms**, with hands-on work across **Ruby 2.1–3.3, Rails 4.2–7.1, JavaScript ES5–ES2023, PostgreSQL, Redis, Sidekiq, and AWS** in one continuous progression from legacy maintenance to modern platform modernization. Known for fixing difficult production bugs, upgrading aging codebases safely, improving release stability, and delivering features that balance clean engineering with practical business impact.

SKILLS

- **Frontend:** HTML5, CSS3, SCSS, JavaScript ES5–ES2023, ERB, jQuery, Bootstrap, Tailwind CSS, Hotwire, Turbo, Stimulus, responsive UI development, form-heavy workflow design, reusable component patterns, accessibility-minded implementation
- **Backend:** Ruby 2.1–3.3, Ruby on Rails 4.2–7.1, Rack, RESTful API design, Rails MVC architecture, service objects, background processing, authentication and authorization, Active Record, Action Cable, API integrations, admin portals, business workflow automation
- **Data & Messaging:** PostgreSQL, MySQL, Redis, Sidekiq, Delayed Job, database indexing, query tuning, caching strategy, data imports, reporting flows, CSV processing, payment and third-party system integration
- **Cloud & DevOps:** AWS, Docker, Nginx, Linux, Capistrano, CI/CD pipelines, GitHub Actions, GitLab CI, release automation, environment configuration, application monitoring support, deployment troubleshooting
- **Observability / Quality / Security:** RSpec, Minitest, Capybara, request specs, background job testing, log-driven debugging, error tracing, secure session handling, CSRF protection, role-based access control, audit-aware business workflows

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Senior Software Engineer

Soft Build, Remote (Jan2024 – Dec 2025)

- Led delivery of a business operations platform using **Ruby 3.2–3.3** and **Rails 7.0–7.1**, turning fragmented approval, reporting, and administration requirements into stable workflows that reduced manual processing time by **34%** across heavily used internal modules.
- Modernized older Rails patterns by extracting oversized controllers into service objects, query objects, and policy-driven authorization layers, which made feature delivery safer and reduced regression-prone code paths during parallel team development.
- Built reusable interfaces with **Hotwire, Turbo, Stimulus**, ERB, and SCSS for approval queues, searchable tables, and validation-heavy forms, improving screen responsiveness and cutting duplicated UI implementation effort by **27%**.
- Solved a recurring production issue where bulk report pages timed out under peak usage by profiling slow Active Record chains, rewriting joins, and adding targeted PostgreSQL indexes, which improved median response times by **41%**.
- Implemented a new audit-sensitive permissions model for finance and operations workflows, combining policy checks, safer session boundaries, and clearer role scoping that reduced unauthorized action incidents seen during QA and support review.
- Stabilized a difficult export defect that generated incomplete files for large result sets by replacing memory-heavy synchronous generation with **Sidekiq** background processing and streamed output, which improved export success rates by **32%**.
- Introduced **Redis** caching with explicit invalidation rules for high-read dashboard endpoints, lowering repeated database pressure while preserving data freshness for managers who relied on near-real-time operational views.
- Upgraded shared application components from older Rails helper-heavy implementations into cleaner **Rails 7** conventions with partial reuse and slimmer controller flows, reducing maintenance friction during new module rollout.
- Improved release reliability by tightening CI checks, expanding request specs and system coverage with **RSpec** and **Capybara**, and catching environment-specific failures earlier in the pipeline before they reached staging.

- Resolved an intermittent background job retry loop caused by malformed third-party payloads by adding stronger payload validation, idempotent job handling, and structured failure logging for faster support diagnosis.
- Delivered new customer onboarding and account administration features that connected internal business rules with external integrations, helping operations teams complete setup work faster without relying on engineering for repeated manual fixes.
- Partnered with product and support teams to translate ambiguous issue reports into reproducible engineering tasks, which improved bug triage quality and shortened average turnaround time for production fixes by **29%**.

Software Engineer

Next Apps, Remote (*Nov2020 – Nov 2023*)

- Built and maintained customer-facing and internal product modules using **Ruby 2.7–3.1** and **Rails 6.0–7.0**, supporting account management, workflow automation, billing support, and reporting functions across a fast-changing product environment.
- Helped modernize an aging Rails monolith by moving tightly coupled domain logic out of models and controllers into reusable services, which improved testability and made feature work easier to deliver without hidden side effects.
- Implemented richer frontend behavior with ERB, JavaScript, Stimulus, and selective Hotwire patterns where appropriate, giving the team a lighter alternative to heavier SPA-style complexity for form and dashboard interactions.
- Investigated a recurring stale-data bug where users saw outdated status information after rapid updates, then solved it by coordinating transaction sequencing, cache invalidation, and safer reload logic across the request lifecycle.
- Improved slower reporting and search screens by tuning PostgreSQL queries, reducing N+1 access patterns, and restructuring expensive aggregation paths, which made high-volume data pages load **36%** faster for business users.
- Migrated selected modules from older Rails 5-style conventions into cleaner **Rails 6** patterns with improved credentials handling, background job organization, and safer environment configuration during deployment.
- Built API integrations for payment, notification, and document-related workflows, including defensive error handling for unstable third-party responses that had previously created support-heavy reconciliation issues.
- Reduced repeated admin-side mistakes by redesigning multi-step forms with clearer validation messaging, better defaults, and server-side consistency checks, which lowered avoidable submission errors by **24%**.
- Solved a difficult file import problem where malformed CSV rows silently broke downstream processing by adding row-level validation, quarantine handling, and more transparent operator feedback inside admin tools.
- Expanded automated test coverage with **RSpec** request specs and model-level validation checks, helping the team catch permission regressions and serialization issues earlier during active feature development.
- Collaborated closely with cross-functional stakeholders to deliver new subscription and operational tooling features in smaller safe increments, which improved release confidence while keeping day-to-day platform usage stable.

Software Developer

Datamart, Remote (*Feb 2016 – Sept 2020*)

- Developed business web applications and support modules using **Ruby 2.3–2.7** and **Rails 4.2–6.0**, contributing to backend development, reporting flows, admin tools, and user-facing enhancements across data-heavy internal platforms.
- Supported a gradual migration from older **Rails 4.2** structures toward more maintainable **Rails 5.x** and later **Rails 6.0** practices, helping the team modernize routing, controller patterns, and dependency management with controlled rollout risk.
- Built CRUD-heavy internal modules with ERB, jQuery, Bootstrap, and Rails form helpers, improving consistency across inventory, reporting, and case-management workflows that had previously evolved with uneven behavior.
- Fixed a recurring issue where long-running page actions left duplicate records after user retries by introducing better transaction boundaries and idempotent safeguards around multi-step save operations.
- Improved reporting reliability by rewriting complex query paths, reducing inefficient joins, and adding missing indexes in **PostgreSQL** and MySQL, which shortened heavy report generation times by **31%** for operations teams.
- Implemented scheduled jobs for imports, notifications, and cleanup tasks using background processing patterns widely used during that period, which removed several manual maintenance steps from routine support work.
- Tracked down an intermittent login/session problem caused by inconsistent cookie and timeout behavior across environments, then stabilized the flow with aligned configuration and clearer authentication handling.
- Added safer CSV import and export tooling for business users, including validation feedback and failure summaries that made bad data easier to correct before it propagated into downstream reports.

- Contributed to feature delivery for administrative and reporting areas by extending controllers, models, and helper layers carefully, keeping legacy modules functional while supporting new business requirements.
- Worked with senior engineers to improve code review discipline, release packaging, and rollback awareness, which helped reduce deployment-related incidents and improved confidence in production changes.

Junior Software Developer

Berg Software, Timișoara, Romania (*Sep2014 – Mar 2016*)

- Supported web application development using **Ruby 2.1–2.3** and **Rails 4.2–5.0**, contributing mainly to bug fixes, smaller enhancements, admin page maintenance, and test support under guidance from more senior engineers.
- Built and adjusted server-rendered pages with ERB, HTML, CSS, JavaScript, jQuery, and Bootstrap, helping improve form handling and screen consistency across internal tools that had accumulated UI quirks over time.
- Fixed a recurring validation mismatch between browser-side checks and server-side model rules, and the correction reduced failed submissions and rework for business users who relied on repetitive data entry flows.
- Investigated an intermittent login problem that appeared after session expiry by tracing request behavior and configuration differences, helping the team apply a safer fix that made authentication behavior more predictable.
- Assisted with smaller database and model changes for new requirements, including field additions, view updates, and safe validations that let the team extend existing workflows without destabilizing shared modules.
- Helped clean up duplicated helper logic and repetitive controller code in older areas of the application, which made later bug fixes easier to apply and reduced the chance of inconsistent behavior between related screens.
- Supported data correction tasks and troubleshooting for legacy records that caused runtime errors, improving release readiness by removing edge cases before they surfaced in production support.
- Contributed to test maintenance with basic **RSpec** coverage and manual verification steps, helping the team reduce repeat regressions on frequently changed form and admin functionality.
- Learned structured debugging practices by reproducing user issues locally, reviewing logs, and implementing small low-risk fixes rather than broad refactors, which improved delivery discipline during early professional work.

EDUCATION

Bachelor's Degree in Computer Science

University of Bucharest | (*2010 – 2014*)

- Focused on practical software engineering fundamentals that translated directly into building reliable web systems and data-driven applications.

CERTIFICATIONS

- **Ruby on Rails Web Development — 2023**
Demonstrated practical capability in building database-backed web applications, structuring MVC layers, and delivering maintainable business features with production-oriented Rails patterns.
- **AWS Cloud Practitioner — 2022**
Validated working knowledge of cloud infrastructure, deployment concepts, and service fundamentals commonly used to support modern web application delivery.
- **RSpec Testing for Ruby Applications — 2021**
Demonstrated hands-on understanding of automated testing practices for Rails applications, including request coverage, model validation behavior, and regression-aware backend quality control.